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Pope calls for end to conflicts around world

DENOUNCES GRAVE SITUATION IN GAZA, SEEKS RELEASE OF HOSTAGES

ROME

Pope Francis called yesterday for “arms to be silenced” around the world in his Christmas address, appealing for peace in the Middle East, Ukraine and Sudan as he denounced the “extremely grave” humanitarian situation in Gaza.

He used his traditional message to the world’s 1.4 billion Catholics to call for talks for a just peace in Ukraine as the country was pummelled by 170 Russian missiles and drones in a Christmas morning barrage Kyiv branded as “inhumane”.

Appeal for ceasefire

His voice breathless, the 88-year-old pontiff also appealed for a ceasefire in Gaza and for the freeing of Israeli hostages held there by Hamas.

“I think of the Christian communities in Israel and Palestine, particularly in Gaza, where the humanitarian situation is extremely grave,” he told thousands of the faithful gathered in front of St Peter’s Basilica in Rome for the “Urbi et Orbi” (“to the city and the world”) address. “May there be



May there be a ceasefire, may the hostages be released and aid be given to the people worn out by hunger and by war.”

Pope Francis

a ceasefire, may the hostages be released and aid be given to the people worn out by hunger and by war.”

Francis also extended his call for peace to Sudan, which has been ravaged by 20 months of brutal civil war and where millions are under the threat of famine.

—AFP

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■ Rescue workers at the crash site of the Azerbaijan jet near the Kazakh city of Aktau. The plane was flying from the Azerbaijani capital Baku to city of Grozny in Chechnya.

29 out of 67 on board survive as Azerbaijani plane crashes

Accident occurred as aircraft made an emergency landing

ASTANA, KAZAKHSTAN

An Azerbaijan Airlines passenger jet with 67 people on board crashed yesterday in western Kazakhstan after veering from its scheduled route, officials said.

Azerbaijani authorities said 29 people had survived the crash of the Embraer 190 near the city of Aktau, an oil and gas hub on the eastern shore of the Caspian Sea.

The plane was flying from the Azerbaijani capital Baku on the western shore of the Caspian to the city of Grozny in Chechnya in southern Russia.

“A plane doing the Baku-Grozny route crashed near the city of Aktau. It belongs to Azerbaijan Airlines,” the Kazakh transport ministry said on Telegram.

Five crew, 62 passengers

Azerbaijan Airlines, the country’s flag carrier, said the plane had 62 passengers and five crew on board.

It said the plane “made an

emergency landing” around three kilometres from Aktau.

Azerbaijani President Ilham Aliyev cancelled a planned visit to Russia for a summit of leaders of the Commonwealth of Independent States.

The Kazakh transport ministry said the plane was carrying 37 nationals from Azerbaijan, six from Kazakhstan, three from Kyrgyzstan and 16 from Russia. The office of Azerbaijan’s prosecutor general said: “We cannot disclose any investigation results now. All possible scenarios are being examined, and the necessary expert analyses are underway.” —AFP

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